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A Daily World Mask Catalog That Posts Itself

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I recently rekindled one of my eccentric hobbies: a longstanding love for collecting masks! Instead of burying unorganised mask images, notes and bits of research inside some folder on my computer (which I used to do), I thought about turning it into a proper catalog to share to the world, one mask at a time, day after day, for as long as I live, which at the moment, might just be forever ;).

The idea was to build a somewhat detailed record of masks from around the world: their names, origins, the people who created or performed with them, their meanings, and of course, the images that would anchor this trail of information.



Kanaga Mask from Mali. Represents the structure of the universe and a primordial creator bird; central to the Dama funerary ceremony that guides the dead into the ancestral realm.

As much as I revel in the sweet pain of collecting masks, I absolutely groan at the labour involved in sharing the work properly. Searching endlessly for their original

images, taking photographs, tracking down originals to buy, and verifying their histories is a lot of work, satisfying work nonetheless. The the real challenge, however, was figuring out how to move smoothly from collection to sharing to the world. I needed a system that could organise well researched mask entries and their descriptions in a database, match each one with its corresponding image and transform that information into an engaging tweet to be published automatically, day after day.

That curious bent eventually became the automation I built, the process I desire to share with you in this article. I thoroughly enjoyed building it, and my hope is that somewhere within this outline, you will find an idea or two that helps you automate a use case you are equally fascinated by using this process.

Getting the Database Right

I decided to upload all material collected into a simple Excel database. Each row represented one mask with fields outlined as follows:

Day	Posted? (Y/N)	Mask Name	Origin / Culture	Creators / Performers	Meaning & Significance	Tweet Draft (ready to paste)	Image Source Hint	Hashtags	Image Filename (local)
1	N	Mwana Pwo	Chokwe people — Angola, DR Congo, Zambia	Carved by Chokwe male artisans; danced by trained male performers	An idealized ancestral woman embodying beauty and fertility; worn during Mukanda male initiation rites to honor female ancestors and guide initiates into adulthood.	Mask #1: Mwana Pwo (Chokwe, Angola/DR Congo/Zambia) 🇶🇩 🇪🇬 🇪🇨 Carved by Chokwe artisans, danced by initiated men.	Search 'Chokwe Pwo mask' on Met Museum Open Access or British Museum Collection Online	#AfricanArt #MaskADay #Chokwe	dav001_mwana.jpg
2	N	Kanaga Mask	Dogon people — Mali	Carved by Dogon blacksmiths (inna); danced by members of the Awa society	Represents the structure of the universe and a primordial creator bird; central to the Dama funerary ceremony that guides the dead into the ancestral realm.	Represents an idealized ancestral woman Mask #2: Kanaga (Dogon, Mali) 🇲🇱 🇪🇬 Carved by Dogon blacksmiths, danced by the Awa society. Its double-cross form maps the cosmos and helps guide the souls of the dead.	Search 'Dogon Kanaga mask' on Musée du quai Branly or Wikimedia Commons	#AfricanArt #MaskADay #Dogon	dav002_kanaga.jpg

- Day
- Posted status
- Mask name
- Origin and culture
- Creators or performers
- Meaning and significance
- Final tweet draft
- Image filename

I needed to make sure that the spreadsheet became the single, canonised repository of information, with each row containing standardised texts alongside their aligned image filenames, to create the consistency needed to run the system. My job would

be to consistently type each mask's information into the database, while my system automates the publishing of tweets.

The Publishing Script

From there, the system would take the draft tweet structure I had created, populate it with the relevant details for each mask, attach the correct image and publish the tweet at a set time each day without any interventions. No magic here, just transforming each mask's stored description into an engaging tweet, paired with its corresponding image. To do this effectively, I needed to write a python script. The script's job was to follow the simple logical steps below:

1. Access my database.
2. Find the first mask where 'Posted? = N'.
3. Read the tweet draft
4. Find the corresponding image.
5. Upload the image.
6. Publish the post.
7. Wait for confirmation.
8. After confirmation, change the database entry from N to Y

```
def select_next_mask(records):  
    unposted_masks = [  
        mask for mask in records  
        if mask["Posted? (Y/N)"].strip().upper() != "Y"  
    ]  
  
    if not unposted_masks:  
        raise RuntimeError("mask has already been posted.")  
  
    return unposted_masks[0]
```

Code snippet for logic 2. Searches the database and returns the first mask whose `Posted?` value has not been changed to `Y`

Safety Before Automation

Before allowing the system to publish anything publicly, I ran a test first. The last thing I wanted was to automate my way into embarrassment. Running the script normally produced a complete preview: the mask that had been selected, the image the system had found and the full tweet and its character count. Nothing, however, was actually published. The script would only connect to X and post when I explicitly added the `--live` flag. That gave me a safe environment to test the workflow before letting it loose on the internet.



I then validated the entire catalog. I had started with 30 entries, and every one of them matched correctly with its corresponding image. The first test run selected *Mwana Pwo*, a Chokwe mask tradition associated with Angola, the Democratic Republic of Congo, and Zambia. The preview came out exactly as I had expected. I then connected the script to the X API, ran the live command and watched the first mask publish successfully. Good times. It was quite the dopamine rush, I'll tell you!

GitHub Actions, The Final Piece

At this point, I had built a working publishing tool, and could watch it select the next mask and publish the post, but I still had to be present to start the process. That was when I discovered GitHub Actions.

After a little learning and experimentation, I moved the system into a GitHub repository and created a scheduled workflow that could run the automation at a set time each day. In summary the system now:

1. Opens the catalog's repository.
2. Reads the database.
3. Finds the next unposted mask.
4. Corroborates the image.
5. Posts the tweet and image combo to X.

6. Marks that mask as posted.
7. Saves the updated database back into the repository.
8. Stops until the next scheduled run.

The database therefore becomes both a content source and a publication ledger. Yesterday's mask becomes Y, while tomorrow's remains N. We're live!



Tony Anumel @L_vcian · 21h

Mask #1: Mwana Pwo (Chokwe, Angola/DR Congo/Zambia) 🇳🇮 🇷🇺 🇸🇩



Carved by Chokwe artisans, danced by initiated men.

Represents an idealized ancestral woman — beauty, fertility, and moral guidance for young initiates.

[#AfricanArt](#) [#MaskADay](#)



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What I loved about this process

The most compelling part was that I built this system on a few simple components:

1. Excel for structured content
2. Python for the automating logic

3. X API for publishing
4. GitHub for version control
5. GitHub Actions for scheduling

Once those pieces were connected properly, the result became autonomous.

The Overarching Aim

The catalog currently contains only a month of material so far. My next goal is to expand it to roughly six months of masks from different cultural traditions around the world.



Hahoe Mask. Traditionally carved from alder wood by village craftsmen from Hahoe Village, Andong, South Korea. Used in a satirical mask drama to poke fun at the nobility, monks, and social hierarchy during village shaman festivals.

Once the collection is large enough, I look to extend the same system to other platforms and possibly build a broader visual archive around it. At that point, it will become a living artefact, which showcases how human beings, despite our separation by geography and history, have grappled with authority, fear, protection, death, transformation, celebration and identity through our representation of masks. That's where my love for collecting masks lies.

Follow my handle @L_vcian on X to discover one remarkable mask each day , among all things data, sports and my random thoughts.

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